

INSTRUCTIONAL GUIDANCE USING MATERIALS WITH RACIAL
SLURS, HATE SPEECH, AND SENSITIVE CONTENT

Loudoun County Public Schools acknowledges that in order to accurately represent historical and current realities, some instructional materials may include sensitive language and speech. The purpose of this regulation is to provide expectations for staff when the use of an instructional resource includes racial slurs, hate speech, or sensitive language.

A. Common Instructional Materials. When teaching a common instructional resource, whole or small group instruction, that contains sensitive language and/or racial slurs, the following expectations must be followed.

1. Prior to teaching the lesson:
 - a. Select high-quality instructional materials that align with curriculum and Policy 5045.
 - b. DO NOT allow racial slurs or hate speech to be spoken or played aloud. Have students read the text silently or if the instructional material is a film, select excerpts without the hate speech.
 - (i) The one exception is when students have an IEP which requires read-aloud access to audiobooks. In this situation, measures should be taken to support the student's processing of content and emotional well-being.
 - c. Work with your collaborative learning team (CLT) or other colleagues in the selection of materials and instructional practices. Reach out to the appropriate content office if you need support. When engaging students in sensitive content do not work in isolation.
 - d. Establish classroom norms and expectations for discussion.
 - e. Provide students with voice and choice with a variety of high-quality instructional materials.
 - f. Communicate with families that many instructional materials are used in the classroom. Encourage families to discuss what the student is learning, reading, writing, or viewing with their children. Examples of communication methods to use with families include but are not limited to curriculum documents, syllabi, websites, and newsletters. Additionally, teachers may provide a list of books or other instructional materials to families.

- g. Be aware that racial slurs and sensitive language may cause students to become uncomfortable, and some may experience marginalization and trauma. Families and school counselors should be informed when reactions interrupt student learning.

2. During the lesson:
 - a. Introduce the assigned instructional resource with a rationale for teaching, alerting students to sensitive and challenging language.
 - (i) An example for addressing this issue might sound like the following: “Slurs toward any group are hate speech and are used to oppress people. These words make our community feel unsafe. Out of respect for all people, we do not use slurs. Sometimes, however, we will see these slurs in written materials. I will not voice this hate speech and you will not voice this hate speech. Together we will learn how these terms negatively impact everyone. Please remember when you leave this classroom, that we expect each of you to be respectful of others and never use racial slurs or hate speech.”
 - b. Note that racial and other slurs are hate speech. Acknowledge the emotional burden that racial slurs and sensitive language create in our community.
 - c. Denounce the use of racial slurs and derogatory remarks about groups of people and explain their oppression of people. While denouncing, staff should never use the slur.
 - d. Provide historical instructional materials for students to understand the connections to contemporary times and their own lives. Acknowledge the perspective of the creator and explain how their background influences the instructional resource. Consider and discuss source credibility and bias when sharing and discussing materials.
 - e. Validate the feelings of students who are and/or express discomfort or pain.
 - f. Allow students who express discomfort and a desire to stop reading the assigned instructional resource to read and study an alternate instructional resource.

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- g. Remind students that their discussions inside and beyond the classroom should be respectful and never include racial slurs or hate speech.
- 3. After the lesson:
 - a. Build in ample time for debriefing; include journal writing for students uncomfortable talking aloud about their experiences.
 - b. Allow opportunities for private reflection and feedback from students to the teacher.
 - c. Be aware that racial slurs and sensitive language cause students to become uncomfortable and some experience marginalization and trauma. Families and school counselors should be informed when reactions interrupt student learning.

B. Student Self-Selected Instructional Materials. When students read self-selected individual or small group instructional materials with sensitive language and/or racial slurs the following expectations must be followed:

- 1. Communicate regularly with families about upcoming units of study, assignments, and projects, especially ones involving sensitive content. This is of particular importance when students are selecting topics for assignments. For example, it is common for students to select a research topic in classrooms.
- 2. Encourage students to share their learning and selections with families and peers so that there is another opportunity to process the content and issues within the instructional resource.
- 3. Be aware that racial slurs and sensitive language cause students to become uncomfortable and some experience marginalization and trauma.
- 4. Encourage students to use LCPS-endorsed instructional materials in school and classroom libraries and online materials.
- 5. Allow students who express discomfort and a desire to stop reading the assigned or self-selected instructional resource to read or view an alternate instructional resource. Encourage the student to express their feelings to a trusted adult, such as the school counselor, teacher, staff member, or family member.
- 6. Support student selection of independent instructional materials with the collaboration of librarians, teachers, and families. Consider the age appropriateness of the materials and the student's interests.

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SLURS, HATE SPEECH, AND SENSITIVE CONTENT

7. Ensure that students and teachers reading passages with sensitive language or racial slurs, do not read the passage aloud or omit the offensive word or supply a substitute word. When oppressive language is spoken aloud it causes violence and trauma to students and provides tacit permission for students to use these terms outside of the classroom.

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Cross Ref: [Policy 5045](#), Criteria and Selection of Supplemental Instructional Materials